

Dirty Rotten Scoundrels!

ALMOST EVERY DAY we read about money going missing from some poor soul's bank account. You can bet that for every case you hear about, there are 10 more that stay unreported to the media. Then there are those who are just too ashamed to admit that they fell for an Internet scam, or a phishing attack.

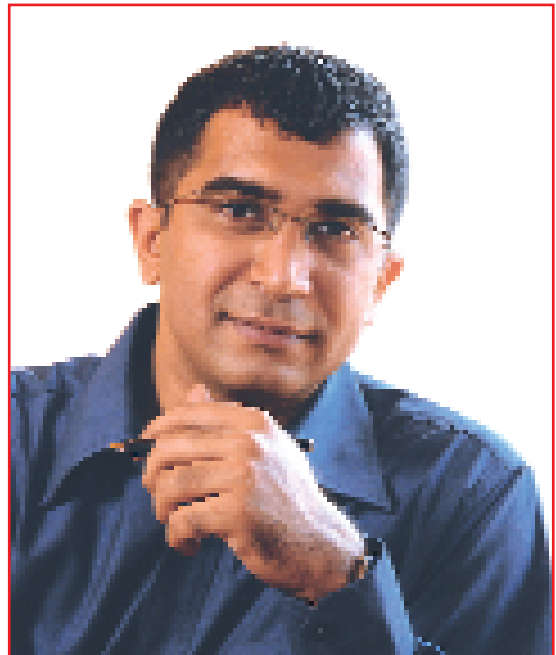
I am reminded about my induction into the world of cyber crime—a few years ago, a consignment of books landed up at my doorstep, and although I hadn't ordered any, I was overjoyed to get them. While I was still trying to figure out which charitable friend had decided to buy me a carton of expensive books, I received my credit card bill. According to the statement, I had bought \$4,000 worth of books from Amazon.com!

Several abusive calls to the credit card company later, I realised that although I was a customer, I certainly wasn't king! Apparently the fine print states that outstanding bills of \$4,000 void you of your right to justice. I was told that I shouldn't have accepted the courier. Perhaps I shouldn't have been naive enough to think that one of my many friends could have sent me books as a gift. Maybe I shouldn't have accepted the credit card from that pushy sales lady... perhaps it was my fault for being born in the first place!

I ran from pillar to post, first lodging a police complaint, then going through the ordeal of filling forms in triplicate, and some in quadruplet. Finally, after six months, my debt was wiped clean, and I returned the books to Amazon. I was lucky that the hacker only used my card to send stuff to me, and not himself—he was probably just using my credit information to hone his skills. how he got it, I still don't know!

Then there was this time in early 2007 when I received news that a leading Indian bank site was being successfully phished. We quickly got to work, trying to trace the owner of the phishing site. Two hours later, we traced the owner of the site back to an ISP in Czechoslovakia, and promptly informed the Delhi Police - Economics and Offences Wing. We also informed the bank, and the offensive site was closed for good.

Although the bank's servers themselves were not compromised, just by creating a look-alike site and



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a very similar domain name, the phisher was able to get hundreds of customer login details. We were assured that no money was lost, and that the phisher was probably using the Indian bank as a guinea pig, training for a much fatter international bank. The bottom line is that we, the customer, need to make sure we don't fall for phishing, pharming and other social-hacks.

Awareness is the need of the day, and I should say that it's heartening that most Indian banks regularly send out warnings to all their customers, and are trying to educate them. However, we need to realise that using technology (like driving), is a privilege, not a right. And the only casualty is always going to be you!



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